

place was in the home, but her father's career as a major general in the army had enabled the family to travel to India periodically, so Ethel's horizons were widened.

Bold early move

At home in England, she had music lessons and, in defiance of her father, decided to pursue a career in the subject. She set off, aged 19, to study at the Conservatoire in Leipzig, where she came into contact with leading composers such as Dvořák, Grieg, and Tchaikovsky. However, she was disappointed with the tuition at the Conservatoire and left after a year to study privately under Heinrich von Herzogenberg, who introduced her to Brahms and Clara Schumann.

Her studies with von Herzogenberg gave her a solid grounding in musical theory, enabling her to progress with her composition, but, as a woman, she struggled to get her music played, until a performance of her Mass in D at the Albert Hall, London, in 1893 to an enthusiastic audience gave her the breakthrough she deserved.

Smyth then turned her attention to opera, beginning with *Der Wald*, which was premiered in Berlin in 1902, and the next year performed at the New York Metropolitan Opera. This was followed by perhaps her best-known work, *The Wreckers*, a three-act opera championed by conductor Thomas Beecham, an admirer of her music.

In 1910, Smyth put her musical career on hold after she met, and fell passionately in love with, the campaigner Emmeline Pankhurst, founder of the Women's Social and Political Union